

03 — Copywriting Guidelines: English + Indonesian

Mandarin Learning App — Bilingual Copywriting Guidelines

Purpose: keep the app voice consistent across English and Indonesian.

This document defines how the app should speak in:

- English
- Indonesian
- Buttons
- Empty states
- Error messages
- Review feedback
- Wrong-answer messages
- Session complete messages
- Onboarding
- Settings
- Progress
- Lesson and review screens

The app should feel simple, friendly, useful, and calm. It should not feel childish, noisy, overly motivational, or textbook-heavy.

1. Core Voice Direction

1.1 App Personality

The app should sound like:

A calm Mandarin coach
A friendly study partner
A simple guide
A practical learning tool

It should not sound like:

A children's game
A strict school teacher
A formal textbook

A loud productivity app
A chatbot with too much personality

1.2 Voice Keywords

Use this style:

Simple
Friendly
Clear
Short
Encouraging
Practical
Respectful
Calm

Avoid:

Too cute
Too formal
Too long
Too technical
Too emotional
Too many emojis
Too much slang

1.3 Main Copy Rule

Every line of copy should help the user do one of these:

Understand what to do
Understand what happened
Feel okay about making mistakes
Continue learning
Review the right thing

If the copy does not help, remove it.

2. Bilingual Style Principles

2.1 English Style

English should be:

Plain
Short
Natural
Beginner-friendly
Warm but not childish

Good:

Not quite. Let's review it once more.

Bad:

Oopsie! That wasn't quite right, superstar! Let's try that magical Mandarin word again!

Bad:

Your submitted response does not correspond with the expected semantic interpretation of the item.

2.2 Indonesian Style

Indonesian should be:

Natural
Simple
Friendly
Not too formal
Not too slang-heavy
Clear

Good:

Belum tepat. Yuk lihat lagi sebentar.

Bad:

Jawaban Anda tidak sesuai dengan interpretasi semantik yang diharapkan oleh sistem.

Bad:

Waduh, salah nih bestie! Coba gas lagi ya!

2.3 Indonesian Pronoun Rule

Use neutral and app-friendly Indonesian.

Recommended:

kamu

Avoid using too much:

Anda

because it can feel too formal.

Avoid:

lu/gue

because it is too casual and regional.

2.4 English Pronoun Rule

Use:

you
your

Avoid overly personal or dramatic phrasing.

Good:

Your review is ready.

Bad:

Your Mandarin destiny awaits.

3. Copy Length Rules

3.1 Maximum Length Guide

Use short copy wherever possible.

Button: 1-3 words
Screen title: 1-4 words
Subtitle/helper text: 1 sentence
Review feedback: 1-2 short sentences
Error message: 1-2 short sentences
Empty state: 1 title + 1 short explanation + 1 action

3.2 One Idea Per Line

Good:

Review ready.
Practice your due items now.

Bad:

Your review session is now ready and you can practice all the items that are due today so your memory stays strong.

3.3 Avoid Over-Explaining

The app should teach through lessons and reviews, not through long UI copy.

Good:

You have 6 reviews due.

Bad:

According to your spaced repetition schedule, 6 learning items have reached their review interval and should now be recalled to strengthen memory retention.

4. Terminology

Use consistent terms across the app.

4.1 Core Terms — English

Today
Lesson
Review
Practice
Progress
Library
Settings
New words
Sentences
Patterns
Hanzi
Components
Tone
Pinyin
Meaning
Mnemonic
Stage
Weak area
Daily goal

4.2 Core Terms — Indonesian

Hari Ini
Pelajaran
Review
Latihan
Progress
Library
Pengaturan
Kata Baru
Kalimat
Pola
Hanzi
Komponen
Nada
Pinyin
Arti
Mnemonic
Tahap
Area Lemah
Target Harian

4.3 Translation Notes

Review

Keep as:

Review

Reason: Indonesian learners commonly understand “review” in app/learning context. “Ulasan” sounds like product review, and “tinjauan” sounds too formal.

Library

Keep as:

Library

Reason: “Perpustakaan” feels too physical and formal. “Library” is common in apps.

Progress

Keep as:

Progress

Reason: widely understood and shorter than “Perkembangan.”

Mnemonic

Use:

Mnemonic

Optional helper explanation:

cara mengingat

Example:

Mnemonic: cara mudah untuk mengingat bentuk, bunyi, atau arti.

Hanzi

Use:

Hanzi

Do not translate as “karakter Cina” everywhere. Use explanation only when needed.

Tone

Use:

Tone

Indonesian UI can use:

Nada

Both are acceptable, but choose one consistently per screen.

Recommendation for Indonesian app:

Nada

5. Capitalization Rules

5.1 English

Use sentence case for most UI copy.

Good:

Start lesson
Review now
Daily goal
Session complete

Avoid title case everywhere:

Start Lesson
Review Now
Daily Goal
Session Complete

5.2 Indonesian

Use sentence case.

Good:

Mulai pelajaran
Review sekarang

Target harian
Sesi selesai

Avoid unnecessary capitalization:

Mulai Pelajaran
Review Sekarang
Target Harian
Sesi Selesai

5.3 Main Navigation Exception

Navigation labels can use title-style short labels for neatness.

English:

Today
Review
Library
Progress
Settings

Indonesian:

Hari Ini
Review
Library
Progress
Pengaturan

6. Punctuation Rules

6.1 Keep Punctuation Light

Use periods for full sentences.

Good:

You're done for today.

Avoid excessive punctuation:

You're done for today!!! 🎉🔥

6.2 Exclamation Marks

Use rarely.

Allowed:

Nice work!
Great progress!

Avoid:

Amazing!!! You crushed it!!!

6.3 Emojis

Use minimal emojis.

Recommended:

No emoji by default
Optional 1 emoji on milestone moments only

Allowed examples:

🎉 Session complete
🔥 7-day streak

Avoid using emojis in every feedback message.

7. Button Labels

Buttons should be short and action-focused.

7.1 Primary Buttons

Context	English	Indonesian
Start daily session	Start today	Mulai hari ini
Start lesson	Start lesson	Mulai pelajaran
Start review	Review now	Review sekarang
Continue	Continue	Lanjut
Finish	Finish	Selesai
Save	Save	Simpan
Try again	Try again	Coba lagi
Next	Next	Berikutnya
Back	Back	Kembali
Skip	Skip	Lewati
Check answer	Check	Cek
Submit answer	Submit	Kirim
Show answer	Show answer	Lihat jawaban
Review mistake	Review again	Review lagi

7.2 Review Buttons

For V1 simplified review actions:

English	Indonesian	Use
Forgot	Lupa	User did not remember
Got it	Bisa	User remembered correctly

Alternative Indonesian:

Ingat

But recommended:

Bisa

Reason: short, natural, and works for recognition/recall.

7.3 Avoid These Button Labels

Avoid vague labels:

Okay
Proceed
Confirm action
Execute
Submit response

Better:

Continue
Start review
Save changes
Check

8. Navigation Copy

8.1 Main Navigation

English:

Today
Lessons
Review
Library
Progress
Settings

Indonesian:

Hari Ini
Pelajaran
Review
Library
Progress
Pengaturan

8.2 Recommended V1 Navigation

To keep the app simple:

English:

Today
Review
Library
Progress
Settings

Indonesian:

Hari Ini
Review
Library
Progress
Pengaturan

Lesson access can live inside Today.

9. Onboarding Copy

Onboarding should be short. Do not ask unnecessary questions in V1.

V1 onboarding should set:

Script preference: Simplified / Traditional
Daily time: 5 / 10 / 15 minutes
Language: English / Indonesian
Optional notification preference

Do not include goal selection in V1 unless it changes the app experience.

9.1 Welcome Screen

English:

Learn Mandarin in small daily steps.
Build words, tones, and sentences with short lessons and reviews.

Indonesian:

Belajar Mandarin sedikit demi sedikit setiap hari.
Bangun kosakata, nada, dan kalimat lewat pelajaran singkat dan review.

Primary button:

Get started
Mulai

9.2 Language Selection

English:

Choose your app language.
You can change this later in Settings.

Indonesian:

Pilih bahasa aplikasi.
Kamu bisa mengubahnya nanti di Pengaturan.

Options:

English
Bahasa Indonesia

9.3 Script Selection

English:

Which characters do you want to learn?

Options:

Simplified
Traditional

Helper:

You can switch this later.

Indonesian:

Karakter mana yang ingin kamu pelajari?

Options:

Simplified
Traditional

Helper:

Kamu bisa menggantinya nanti.

9.4 Daily Time Selection

English:

How much time do you want to study each day?

Options:

5 minutes
10 minutes
15 minutes

Indonesian:

Berapa lama kamu ingin belajar setiap hari?

Options:

5 menit
10 menit
15 menit

9.5 Onboarding Complete

English:

You're ready.
Start your first short lesson.

Indonesian:

Kamu siap.
Mulai pelajaran singkat pertamamu.

Button:

Start lesson
Mulai pelajaran

10. Today Page Copy

The Today page should tell the user what to do next.

10.1 Ready State

English:

Today's Mandarin
You have a short lesson and 6 reviews ready.

Indonesian:

Mandarin hari ini
Ada pelajaran singkat dan 6 review untukmu.

Buttons:

Start lesson
Review now

Mulai pelajaran
Review sekarang

10.2 Only Review State

English:

Review ready
Practice your due items now.

Indonesian:

Review siap
Latih item yang sudah waktunya di-review.

10.3 Only Lesson State

English:

New lesson ready
Learn a few new words today.

Indonesian:

Pelajaran baru siap
Pelajari beberapa kata baru hari ini.

10.4 Nothing Due State

English:

You're done for now.
Come back later for your next review.

Indonesian:

Selesai untuk sekarang.
Kembali lagi nanti untuk review berikutnya.

10.5 No New Lesson Available

English:

No new lesson right now.
You can review old items or check your Library.

Indonesian:

Belum ada pelajaran baru saat ini.
Kamu bisa review item lama atau lihat Library.

11. Lesson Page Copy

Lesson copy should be calm and focused.

11.1 Lesson Start

English:

New words
Learn these first, then you'll review them later.

Indonesian:

Kata baru
Pelajari ini dulu, nanti akan muncul lagi di review.

11.2 Hanzi Explanation Labels

English:

Meaning
Pinyin
Tone
Components
Mnemonic
Example

Indonesian:

Arti
Pinyin
Nada
Komponen
Mnemonic
Contoh

11.3 Mnemonic Intro

English:

A quick way to remember it:

Indonesian:

Cara cepat untuk mengingatnya:

11.4 Tone Helper

English:

Listen for the tone shape.

Indonesian:

Perhatikan bentuk nadanya.

11.5 Lesson Complete

English:

Lesson complete.
These items will appear in your reviews.

Indonesian:

Pelajaran selesai.
Item ini akan muncul di review kamu.

Button:

Continue
Lanjut

12. Review Page Copy

Review copy should be fast and minimal.

12.1 Review Start

English:

Review time
Recall what you learned before.

Indonesian:

Waktunya review
Ingat kembali yang sudah kamu pelajari.

12.2 Question Prompts

Question type	English	Indonesian
Meaning	What does this mean?	Apa artinya?
Hanzi	Which hanzi matches this?	Hanzi mana yang cocok?
Pinyin	What is the pinyin?	Apa pinyinnya?
Tone	What is the tone?	Apa nadanya?
Tone pattern	What is the tone pattern?	Bagaimana pola nadanya?
Audio	What did you hear?	Apa yang kamu dengar?
Sentence	What does this sentence mean?	Apa arti kalimat ini?
Fill blank	Fill in the blank.	Isi bagian kosong.

12.3 Review Actions

English:

Forgot
Got it

Indonesian:

Lupa
Bisa

12.4 Correct Answer Feedback

Use variety, but keep it short.

English:

Correct.
Nice.
Good.
Got it.
Well done.

Indonesian:

Benar .
Bagus .
Sip .
Bisa .
Mantap .

Recommended default:

English:

Correct .

Indonesian:

Benar .

Do not over-celebrate every correct answer.

12.5 Wrong Answer Feedback

Wrong feedback should be encouraging and useful.

English:

Not quite. Let's review it once more.

Indonesian:

Belum tepat. Yuk lihat lagi sebentar.

Alternative English:

Almost. The correct answer is below.

Alternative Indonesian:

Hampir. Jawaban yang benar ada di bawah.

12.6 Tone Mistake Feedback

English:

The syllable is right, but the tone is different.

Indonesian:

Suku katanya sudah benar, tapi nadanya berbeda.

English:

This is 3rd tone. Let your voice dip low.

Indonesian:

Ini nada ke-3. Turunkan suara, lalu naik sedikit.

12.7 Pinyin Mistake Feedback

English:

Check the pinyin again.

Indonesian:

Cek lagi pinyinnya.

12.8 Meaning Mistake Feedback

English:

The meaning is different. Review the example sentence.

Indonesian:

Artinya berbeda. Lihat lagi contoh kalimatnya.

12.9 Session Complete

English:

Review complete.
You practiced 12 items today.

Indonesian:

Review selesai.
Kamu melatih 12 item hari ini.

Alternative:

English:

Nice work. Your next reviews will appear later.

Indonesian:

Bagus. Review berikutnya akan muncul nanti.

13. Wrong-Answer Panel Copy

The wrong-answer panel should be helpful, not punishing.

13.1 Panel Structure

Use this order:

1. Gentle feedback
2. Correct answer
3. Short explanation

- 4. Mnemonic or example
- 5. Continue button

13.2 English Template

Not quite.
Correct answer: hǎo
好 means “good.” It uses 3rd tone, so your voice dips low.

Button:

Continue

13.3 Indonesian Template

Belum tepat.
Jawaban benar: hǎo
好 artinya “baik.” Nadanya nada ke-3, jadi suara turun rendah dulu.

Button:

Lanjut

13.4 Do Not Say

Avoid:

Wrong.
Incorrect.
You failed.
This should be easy.
You already learned this.

Indonesian avoid:

Salah.
Kamu gagal.

Masa lupa?
Ini kan gampang.

14. Empty States

Empty states should explain what happened and what the user can do.

14.1 No Reviews

English:

No reviews right now.
You're caught up for the moment.

Button:

Go to Today

Indonesian:

Belum ada review saat ini.
Kamu sudah selesai untuk sekarang.

Button:

Ke Hari Ini

14.2 No Lessons

English:

No new lessons right now.
Keep reviewing while new content unlocks.

Indonesian:

Belum ada pelajaran baru saat ini.
Tetap review sambil menunggu konten baru terbuka.

14.3 Empty Library

English:

Your Library is empty.
Learn your first lesson to add items here.

Indonesian:

Library kamu masih kosong.
Mulai pelajaran pertama untuk menambahkan item di sini.

14.4 No Search Results

English:

No results found.
Try another word or pinyin.

Indonesian:

Tidak ada hasil.
Coba kata atau pinyin lain.

14.5 No Progress Yet

English:

No progress yet.
Complete a lesson or review to start tracking.

Indonesian:

Belum ada progress.
Selesaikan pelajaran atau review untuk mulai melacak.

15. Loading States

Loading copy should be short.

15.1 General Loading

English:

Loading...

Indonesian:

Memuat...

15.2 Session Loading

English:

Preparing your session...

Indonesian:

Menyiapkan sesi kamu...

15.3 Review Loading

English:

Loading reviews...

Indonesian:

Memuat review...

16. Error Messages

Error messages should be clear and non-technical.

16.1 General Error

English:

Something went wrong.
Please try again.

Indonesian:

Ada yang bermasalah.
Coba lagi sebentar.

16.2 Network Error

English:

You seem to be offline.
We'll save your progress when you reconnect.

Indonesian:

Sepertinya kamu sedang offline.
Progress akan disimpan saat tersambung lagi.

16.3 Save Error

English:

Couldn't save your progress.
Please try again.

Indonesian:

Progress belum bisa disimpan.
Coba lagi sebentar.

16.4 Login Error

English:

Couldn't sign you in.
Check your email or try again.

Indonesian:

Belum bisa masuk.
Cek email kamu atau coba lagi.

16.5 Content Error

English:

This item could not load.
Try refreshing the page.

Indonesian:

Item ini belum bisa dimuat.
Coba refresh halaman.

16.6 Avoid Technical Errors in UI

Do not show raw errors as primary copy:

RPC failed: submit_review_answer returned 400
Invalid JSONB payload
Foreign key violation

Instead show:

Couldn't save this answer.
Please try again.

For developers, log technical details separately.

17. Progress Copy

Progress should feel informative, not pressuring.

17.1 Progress Summary

English:

You learned 24 words.
8 are getting stronger.

Indonesian:

Kamu sudah belajar 24 kata.
8 kata mulai semakin kuat.

17.2 Streak Copy

English:

3-day streak
Keep the habit going.

Indonesian:

Streak 3 hari
Lanjutkan kebiasaannya.

17.3 Weak Area Copy

English:

Tone needs more practice.
We'll add more tone reviews.

Indonesian:

Nada masih perlu latihan.
Kami akan menambahkan lebih banyak review nada.

17.4 Encouragement Copy

English:

Small progress counts.

Indonesian:

Progress kecil tetap berarti.

Avoid guilt-based copy:

You missed your goal again.
Don't break your streak.
You are falling behind.

Indonesian avoid:

Kamu gagal lagi.
Jangan rusak streak kamu.
Kamu tertinggal.

18. SRS Stage Copy

SRS stages should feel clear and encouraging.

18.1 Stage Names

Recommended V1 stages:

Stage	English	Indonesian
1	Learning	Belajar
2	Familiar	Mulai kenal
3	Strong	Kuat
4	Mastered	Dikuasai
5	Long-term	Jangka panjang

18.2 Stage Helper Copy

Learning:

New item. Review it soon.

Item baru. Akan segera di-review lagi.

Familiar:

You're starting to remember this.

Kamu mulai mengingat item ini.

Strong:

This is getting stronger.

Item ini mulai kuat.

Mastered:

You know this well.

Kamu sudah cukup menguasai item ini.

Long-term:

Saved for long-term review.

Disimpan untuk review jangka panjang.

19. Settings Copy

Settings should be simple and predictable.

19.1 Settings Labels

English	Indonesian
App language	Bahasa aplikasi
Character style	Gaya karakter
Simplified	Simplified
Traditional	Traditional
Daily study time	Waktu belajar harian
Notifications	Notifikasi
Sound	Suara
Review settings	Pengaturan review
Reset progress	Reset progress
Sign out	Keluar

19.2 Helper Text

App language:

Change the language used in the app.

Ubah bahasa yang digunakan di aplikasi.

Character style:

Choose how Chinese characters are shown.

Pilih tampilan karakter Mandarin.

Daily study time:

Used to plan your daily session size.

Digunakan untuk mengatur ukuran sesi harianmu.

20. Notification Copy

Notifications should be useful, not annoying.

20.1 Review Reminder

English:

Your Mandarin review is ready.

Indonesian:

Review Mandarin kamu sudah siap.

20.2 Gentle Reminder

English:

A short review is waiting.

Indonesian:

Ada review singkat menunggu.

20.3 Streak Reminder

English:

Keep your Mandarin habit going.

Indonesian:

Lanjutkan kebiasaan belajar Mandarinmu.

Avoid guilt:

Don't lose your streak!

Better:

Keep your streak going.

21. Audio and Tone Copy

Tone guidance should be practical.

21.1 Tone Labels

English:

1st tone: high and steady
2nd tone: rising
3rd tone: low dip
4th tone: sharp fall
Neutral tone: light and short

Indonesian:

Nada 1: tinggi dan rata
Nada 2: naik
Nada 3: turun rendah lalu naik sedikit

Nada 4: turun tegas
Nada netral: ringan dan pendek

21.2 Audio Prompt

English:

Listen and choose the answer.

Indonesian:

Dengarkan lalu pilih jawaban.

21.3 Replay Button

English:

Play again

Indonesian:

Putar lagi

22. Library Copy

The Library is where users review learned content outside sessions.

22.1 Library Header

English:

Library
Review words, hanzi, and sentences you've learned.

Indonesian:

Library

Lihat kembali kata, hanzi, dan kalimat yang sudah kamu pelajari.

22.2 Filters

English	Indonesian
All	Semua
Words	Kata
Hanzi	Hanzi
Sentences	Kalimat
Patterns	Pola
Weak areas	Area lemah
Mastered	Dikuasai
Learning	Belajar

22.3 Search Placeholder

English:

Search word, hanzi, or pinyin

Indonesian:

Cari kata, hanzi, atau pinyin

23. Grammar Copy

Grammar copy should avoid academic language.

23.1 Grammar Intro

English:

Pattern
A simple way to use this sentence.

Indonesian:

Pola
Cara sederhana memakai kalimat ini.

23.2 Formula Label

English:

Pattern

Indonesian:

Pola

23.3 Common Mistake Label

English:

Common mistake

Indonesian:

Kesalahan umum

24. Do and Don't Examples

24.1 Review Feedback

Do:

Not quite. 好 is hǎo, 3rd tone.

Belum tepat. 好 dibaca hǎo, nada ke-3.

Don't:

Wrong answer. You need to memorize the tone better.

Salah. Kamu harus hafal nadanya dengan lebih baik.

24.2 Empty State

Do:

No reviews right now. You're caught up.

Belum ada review saat ini. Kamu sudah selesai.

Don't:

There are currently no reviewable SRS objects available for this user.

Tidak terdapat objek SRS yang dapat di-review untuk pengguna ini.

24.3 Progress

Do:

You're getting stronger at tones.

Nada kamu mulai semakin kuat.

Don't:

Your tone accuracy has improved according to recent performance metrics.

Akurasi nada Anda mengalami peningkatan berdasarkan metrik performa terbaru.

25. Bilingual Copy Key Format

For implementation, store copy keys in a structured format.

Recommended format:

```
{
  "review.feedback.wrong.default": {
    "en": "Not quite. Let's review it once more.",
    "id": "Belum tepat. Yuk lihat lagi sebentar."
  },
  "review.feedback.correct.default": {
    "en": "Correct.",
    "id": "Benar."
  }
}
```

25.1 Copy Key Naming Rules

Use predictable namespaces:

```
nav.*
onboarding.*
today.*
lesson.*
review.*
wrong_panel.*
library.*
progress.*
settings.*
error.*
empty.*
loading.*
notification.*
srs.*
```

25.2 Example Keys

```
nav.today
nav.review
nav.library
nav.progress
nav.settings

review.start.title
review.start.subtitle
review.feedback.correct.default
review.feedback.wrong.default
review.feedback.wrong.tone
review.complete.title
review.complete.subtitle

error.general.title
error.general.body
empty.review.title
empty.review.body
```

26. Recommended V1 Copy Set

Minimum copy needed for V1:

```
Navigation labels
Onboarding screens
Today page states
Lesson page labels
Review question prompts
Correct/wrong feedback
Wrong-answer panel
Session complete
Empty states
Loading states
Error states
Settings labels
SRS stage names
Tone labels
Library filters
```

Do not write copy for features that do not exist yet.

27. Final Copy Rules

27.1 Must Follow

Keep it short
Use simple words
One idea at a time
Do not shame mistakes
Do not over-celebrate everything
Keep English and Indonesian meaning aligned
Use consistent terms
Avoid unnecessary emojis
Avoid technical database/app errors in user-facing copy

27.2 North Star

The app should make the user feel:

"I know what to do next, and it's okay if I make mistakes."

English tone:

Clear, calm, useful.

Indonesian tone:

Sederhana, ramah, jelas.